

Draft - expert review pending

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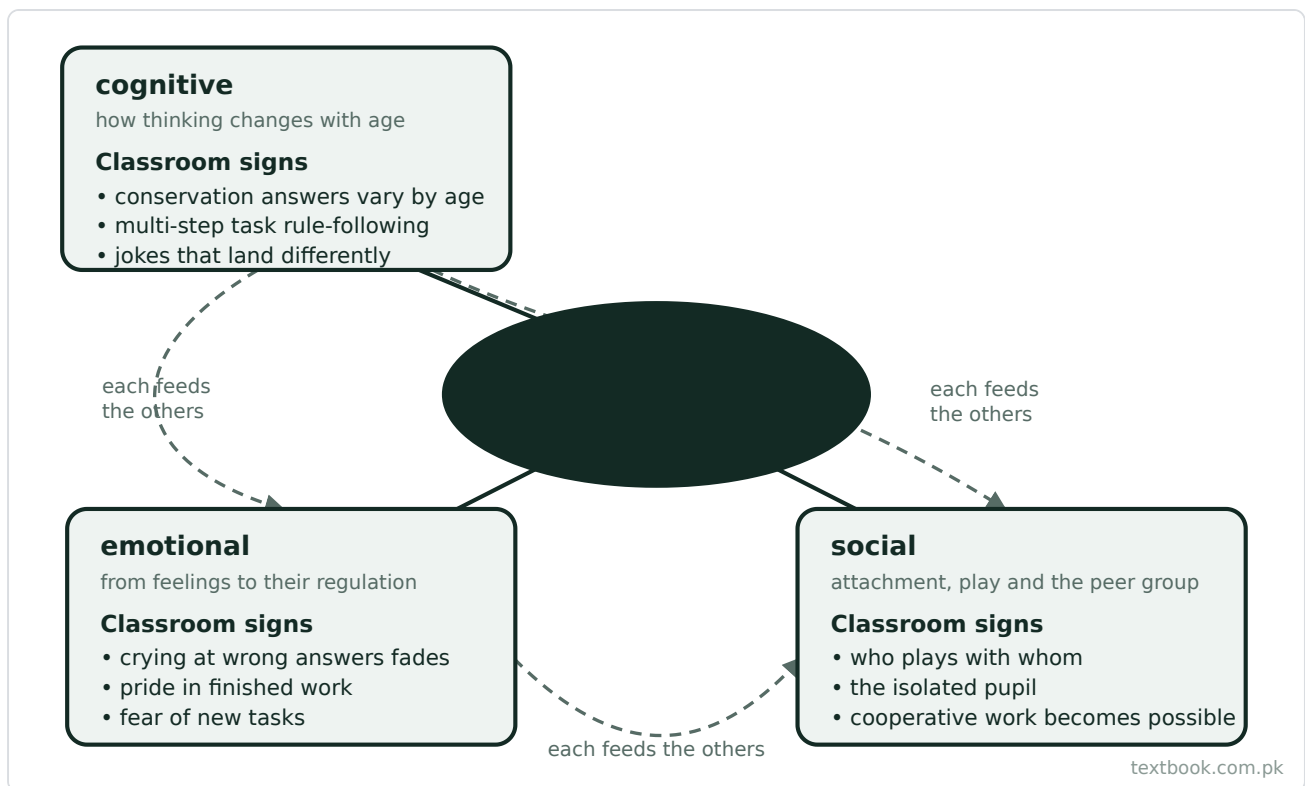
Draft translation - not yet human-reviewed / مسوده ترجمه

Topic 2.3 - Cognitive, emotional and social development

A real classroom situation

Two video clips, filmed in the same Hyderabad school on the same morning, are shown to a B.Ed class every year. In the first, a Class 2 pupil is asked whether the taller of two identical glasses holds more water. Both glasses were filled from the same jug; one was then poured into a tall thin glass. The pupil is certain: the tall glass holds more, "because it is bigger". In the second clip, a Class 5 pupil is asked the same question with the same glasses. She says the amounts are the same, and when asked why, says "because you just poured it - nothing went in or out".

The trainees' first instinct is that the Class 5 pupil is cleverer. The more interesting reading is that she is **older**. Between those two ages, a way of thinking has arrived that no amount of scolding could have hastened in the Class 2 pupil.



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Explanation

Cognitive development: how thinking changes with age

Cognitive Development is long-term change in thinking and memory (Seifert & Sutton, 2009). The best-known account of it is Jean Piaget's stage theory, and this topic takes from it the one thing a teacher most needs: a description of what children of different ages can and cannot yet do with their thinking.

Piaget observed that thinking develops through **stages** - distinct patterns that always occur in the same order, are never skipped, and each transform the one before (Seifert & Sutton, 2009). Four are usually named: sensorimotor (infancy), preoperational (roughly two to seven), concrete operational (roughly seven to eleven), and formal operational (from about eleven). The ages are approximate; the order is not.

For a primary teacher, the boundary that matters is the one the two video clips sit either side of. The **preoperational** pupil is led by how things look and feel right now: the tall glass *looks* bigger, so it holds more. The **concrete**

operational pupil can hold a rule - "if nothing is added or taken away, the amount stays the same" - and apply it to real objects in front of them. Piaget called the classic test of this **conservation**, and the Class 5 pupil's answer ("you just poured it") is the rule-speaking answer.

Two further gains arrive with concrete operations, and both are visible in any lesson. **Reversibility**: the pupil can think through the steps of a process in any order. A Class 3 pupil who can list the steps of a science activity but only in the order they happened is not yet there; a Class 5 pupil can start from the end.

Decentration: the pupil can hold two features of a problem at once - the height of the water *and* the width of the glass - instead of being captured by the most striking one.

The **formal operational** thinking of adolescence goes further: reasoning about representations, hypotheses and possibilities, not only concrete objects. A Class 9 pupil who can test a general claim ("all metals sink" - and find the counter-example) is working formally. Unit 4 of this course returns to this territory; here the point is narrower and more useful: **a pupil's answer can tell you where their thinking is, and that is developmental information, not an ability verdict.**

The misconception to clear now. Trainees often read Piaget as a set of deadlines: a pupil who has not reached a stage "should have by now". The stages carry approximate ages and wide individual variation (Topic 2.1's rate principle). They describe *readiness*, never *worth*. The Class 2 pupil in the video is not a failed Class 5 pupil; she is exactly where nearly every bright seven-year-old is.

Emotional development: from feelings to their regulation

Emotional development is the long movement from having feelings to being able to do something with them. A Class 1 pupil who cries when an answer is wrong and a Class 6 pupil who flushes and tries again are not different in feeling; they are at different points in **regulation** - the capacity to notice an emotion, name it, and choose a response rather than be the response.

Three markers of this development show up in classrooms. First, the **expression** narrows with age: the open weeping of early primary gives way to

the controlled face of later primary, partly because pupils learn what their culture displays where. Second, the **vocabulary** grows: a pupil who can say "I was embarrassed" has a tool a pupil who can only feel it lacks. Third, **strategies** appear: counting to ten, asking for help, trying again tomorrow. None of this is automatic, and all of it is teachable - a teacher who names emotions calmly and models recovery is teaching regulation without ever announcing it.

The famous pupil in this territory is the one who cries in September and laughs in March. The change is not that the feeling went away; it is that the pupil learned, in that room, that a wrong answer was survivable. That is emotional development happening inside a school year, driven by the environment Topic 2.1 described.

Social development: attachment, play and the peer group

Social development is the growth of relationships: the early **attachment** to caregivers, the long apprenticeship of **play**, and the rising power of the **peer group**.

Attachment is the secure base an infant builds with a caregiver; it is the first relationship, and it shapes the expectations a child carries into every later one. By school age its classroom trace is indirect but real: a pupil who trusts adults to be reliable takes more risks with questions than a pupil whose experience says otherwise. That is not a verdict on the pupil; it is a reason for a teacher to be reliable.

Play is where young children rehearse the social world. Watch any primary break time: the negotiated rules of a cricket match with one bat, the turn-taking of a skipping rope, the make-believe of a "school" game. Piaget's preoperational dramatic play - thinking on two levels at once, the banana that is a telephone - is social training as much as cognitive (Seifert & Sutton, 2009).

The peer group's power rises steadily through primary school and peaks in adolescence. Its classroom face is the seating map of who plays with, sits with and works with whom - and the isolated pupil that map reveals. A teacher who draws that map once a term holds social information no mark sheet supplies: which pupils are connected, which are tolerated, and which are invisible.

The three domains are not compartments. The Class 5 pupil's conservation answer is cognitive; her confidence to give it aloud in a room of sixty is social; her recovery when the answer is wrong is emotional. A teacher reads the pupil across all three, and the reading is the point of Topic 2.4.

domain	what grows	a Class 2 vs Class 6 difference	one classroom sign
● cognitive thinking	thinking and memory	certain the tall glass holds more vs explains the pour rule	multi-step instructions followed without reminders
■ emotional regulation	regulation of feelings	crying at a wrong answer vs flushing and trying again	the pupil who laughs in March at what made them cry in September
▲ social peers and play	relationships, play, peers	parallel play beside others vs negotiated games with rules	the seating map of who works with whom
◆ physical recalled from 2.2	body and motor control	large shaky letters vs small even letters	the handwriting on the newest exercise book

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Activity: Three readings of one pupil

In pairs, about 20 minutes.

A colleague describes a Class 4 pupil: "He will not work in groups. He takes the manipulatives and plays with them alone. When the group complains, he shouts. He is bright - his written work is two years ahead - but he is impossible in group work."

1. Write one sentence reading this pupil through the **cognitive** domain, one through the **emotional** domain, and one through the **social** domain.
2. For each reading, name one thing the colleague could try that follows from it.

3. Decide together: which reading does the colleague's current response ("he is impossible") secretly assume, and what does that assumption hide?

Check your understanding

1. State Piaget's four stages in order, with approximate ages. (*Remember*)
2. Explain conservation in your own words, and say what the Class 5 pupil's answer shows that the Class 2 pupil's does not. (*Understand*)
3. Name the two gains of concrete operational thinking (reversibility, decentration) and give a classroom task that needs each. (*Understand*)
4. A pupil cries at every wrong answer in September and rarely does by March. Describe what developed, using this topic's terms, and name what in the room likely drove it. (*Apply*)
5. The colleague in the activity calls the pupil "impossible". Using all three domains, give a two-sentence reply that replaces the label with information. (*Apply*)

Summary

Thinking develops through an ordered sequence of stages - from the look-led reasoning of the preoperational years, through the rule-held reasoning about concrete objects, to the formal reasoning of adolescence - and a pupil's answers reveal where they are, not what they are worth. Emotional development is the movement from having feelings to regulating them, and classrooms are where much of it is practised. Social development runs from attachment through play to the peer group, and its classroom trace is the map of who works with whom. The three domains feed each other, and a teacher reads a pupil across all three.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can name Piaget's four stages in order and say what the concrete operational pupil can do that the preoperational pupil cannot.
- ☐ I can explain conservation with the two-glasses demonstration.

- ☐ I can describe emotional development as regulation, with a classroom example.
- ☐ I can say what attachment, play and the peer group each contribute to social development.
- ☐ I can read one described pupil through all three domains instead of one label.

Try this at your practicum school

Ask your cooperating teacher for the seating plan of one class, and at break time watch the same class for ten minutes. Draw the map of who plays with whom. Compare it with the seating plan, and note one pupil the two maps treat differently. Do not intervene; just notice what the map reveals that the marks do not.

Summative task

Write **250-300 words** on the two video clips.

A trainee watches both clips and concludes: "The Class 2 pupil is weak and the Class 5 pupil is clever." Assess this conclusion. Your answer must say what the clips actually demonstrate (and what they do not), what would need to be true for "weak" and "clever" to be justified conclusions, and what the difference between the two pupils should change for each one's teacher.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong answer shows
Grasp of the stage idea	The clips are read as developmental difference, with the conservation task named accurately.
Assessment of the conclusion	The claim is tested against what would justify it, not merely contradicted. (<i>Analyze</i>)
Teaching consequence	Each pupil's teacher gets a different, doable implication from the same evidence.

Criterion	What a strong answer shows
Plain, accurate writing	Terms used correctly; no padding; within the word count.

Further reading

- Seifert, K., & Sutton, R. (2009). *Educational Psychology* (2nd ed.), Chapter 3. University of Manitoba. CC BY.
<https://open.umn.edu/opentextbooks/textbooks/educational-psychology>
- Vosniadou, S. (2001). *How children learn*. Educational Practices Series No. 7. International Academy of Education / UNESCO IBE. <https://eric.ed.gov/?id=ED455955>

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